OPENING CHALLENGES

With independence came the challenge of maintaining law and order amid the escalating communal carnage. To carry out this task the Punjab Boundary Force, composed of five brigades with 15 Indian and ten Pakistani battalions, came into being, but it was spread too thinly on the ground to make any meaningful impact and was disbanded on 1 September 1947. This was to be the last time that the old Indian Army deployed jointly as one body.

The other challenge was consolidating the 575-odd princely states, of which all except three – Junagadh, Hyderabad and Kashmir – merged without fuss. The first of the three princely states to be addressed was Junagadh, located in what is now the Indian state of Gujarat. When political efforts failed and in a move to pre-empt any Pakistani action to annex it, India prepared a plan for the occupation of Babariawad and Mangrol. The main phase of *Exercise Peace* was executed on 5 October 1947 with the landing of a task force at Porbandar. Phase II was carried out on 17 October when Indian troops landed at Jaffarabad. Phase III followed with landings at Mangrol on 1 November, forcing Junagadh to invite the Government of India to take charge of the state. On 9 November, troops under command of Brigadier Gurdial Singh marched in to assist in taking over Junagadh's civil administration.

Much larger than Junagadh, Hyderabad had a well-organized and -equipped standing army of 22,000 supported by around 200,000 irregulars (the Razakars). In August 1947 Hyderabad bought time to merge with India by signing a 'Standstill Agreement' valid for one year, but as time ran out, India decided to act, aware that Pakistani elements had entered Jammu & Kashmir and much of the Indian Army was kept on standby to deal with the deteriorating situation in the north. One of the few formations available, 1 Armoured Division, was moved to Solapur in the Deccan and allotted 1 Armoured Brigade and 7 and 9 Infantry brigades. The plan to seize Hyderabad envisaged two thrusts, the main effort led by 1 Armoured Division from Solapur in the west, supported by a second thrust by an